

Govier, Trudy. *The Philosophy of Argument*. Newport News, VA: Vale Press, 1999. 264 pages. \$21.45 paper ISBN 0-916475-271 .

Trudy Govier's treatment of argument and argumentation is refreshing and inspiring. This book explains and champions many of the rhetorical dimensions of argument that often are overlooked by critical thinking and argumentation textbooks. Scholars, students, and practitioners of argument who are well-acquainted with how speech communication and communication studies departments have engaged the study of informal argument and public controversy will find in Govier's book a concise and satisfying explication and defense of informal argument as a line of inquiry. Put simply, frequent readers of this journal will find in *The Philosophy of Argument* a healthy and comforting justification for the practical study of informal argument claims and practices.

Govier's chapters are written with the overarching assumption that social and political argument is, at its core, "messy." The philosophy of argument, according to Govier, involves taking a rhetorical turn that foregrounds not just the internal, analytical soundness of arguments, also focuses on the belief-based appeals and the value-laden warrants of argumentative claims. The difference between analytical dimensions and rhetorical dimensions of argument is stated simply – the wide gulf between belief and facts – yet poses complex and sometimes contradictory modes of analysis for argument criticism. Attending to argument criticism with these assumptions reconfigures the tasks of critics. Writes Govier,

As they occur in reality, arguments are more than propositions in timeless relation to each other. Even traditional questions of justification will demand sensitivity to this point, when we see the importance of context in determining whether statements constitute argument, explanation, or description, and when we replace truth criterion for premises with one of acceptability. Acceptability, unlike truth, is acceptability for someone, thus argument cogency is to some extent relative to the audience for whom the argument is intended. (14)

Communication scholars in general, and rhetorical theorists and critics in particular, will find little unique insight from Govier's explanation of these assumptions. Those familiar with Kenneth Burke's reconceptualization of persuasion via identification, Chaim Perelman and Luce Olbrechts-Tyteca's substitution of adherence rather than logical conversion as the domain of informal argument, and Walter Fisher's notion of narrative as a metaphor for

constructing and evaluating public argument will find Govier's conceptual development easily accessible. However, one of the strengths of *The Philosophy of Argument* lies in the fact that one need not be well read in Burke, Perelman, and Fisher to benefit from their conceptual insight into the rhetorical processes that condition argument structure and practice. One familiar with these authors, however, cannot but wonder why such resources – given their conceptual power to help explain Govier's grounding assumptions – go mostly tapped. Nevertheless, this book is comprised of a series of relatively brief but well written and well argued chapters that clearly justify the value of approaching argument, argumentation, and controversy with more theoretical and practical fluidity than linear, analytical models allow.

Chapter one, "Philosophers are More than a Luxury! Politics and Argument Under Uncertainty," is titled in response to an often-referenced statement by political philosopher Benjamin Barber: In a democracy, citizens are necessities whereas philosophers are luxuries. Intended to problematize the dichotomy set forth by Barber – either one is a citizen or one is a philosopher – this first chapter lays out the terms by which informal argument training and controversy management can help forge a third wave democratic political philosophy that portends a more active participating polity, as well more accountable (and amenable) civil- and elected-official institutional forces. "There are good intellectual reasons for appreciating controversy. It serves to expose errors, omissions, false of unexamined assumptions, and careless, unclear terminology.... Participating in controversy can make us more flexible, careful, and open-minded, and can save us from dogmatism" (11).

Chapter two, "Political Speech, Oliver Sacks and the Credibility Concern," addresses the role of credibility in argument assessment. By forming the backdrop from which attributions about character emerge, extra-verbal considerations influence how "acceptable" an argument may or may not be to particular audiences at particular times. These considerations, suggests Govier, appear to exist independent of the substantive merit of a given argument. To explain this position, Govier reviews the *tu quoque* ("you too") fallacy, a variant on the *ad hominem* attack. Raising a *tu quoque* challenge means charging one with hypocrisy: an advocate's argument deserves to be dismissed on the grounds that the advocate behaves/thinks in ways inconsistent with what is being advocated. While this fallacy does little to attack the merits of one's argument, it often contributes to a damaging

credibility attack – one that is grounded in moral considerations of justice and equity.

Govier's guidelines for how citizens and critics can usefully navigate through the concerns of argument validity one on the one hand, and democratic "equity" concerns on the other, provide a useful and convenient means by which to consider not just *tu quoque* fallacies in particular, but *ad hominem* charges in general.

Chapter three translates most easily into pedagogical practice. "When Logic Meets Politics: Testimony, Distrust, and Rhetorical Disadvantage" develops a useful model that divides testimonial evidence evaluation into eight sequential propositions. A universal model may seem to run counter to Govier's insistence that critics and practitioners appreciate the nuances of rhetorical controversy, yet readers are treated to a commendable justification for retaining evaluation standards across multiple contexts. Short of endorsing casuistry, and far short of retreating to intellectual solipsism, Govier crafts this model with an eye toward rigorous pedagogy and responsible scholarship. I suggest that we can continue to state and explain norms and criteria for epistemic appraisal in universalistic terms – while granting there are important truths in the feminist allegations that such norms can work selectively. In practice, it is all too easy to interpret and apply criteria in such a way as to marginalize and discredit those who are rhetorically disadvantaged. The solution, I suggest, is to be found in offering further guidance for the interpretation and application of these norms. Such guidance is intended to protect us from those political-epistemic temptations that may prevent us from hearing and believing what others have to say. Legitimizing testimonial claims of marginalized groups and persons involves more than allowing said speakers to voice an opinion. Instead, maintains Govier, progressive democratic politics involves changing the ways in which polity members "hear" one another.

Chapter four seeks to expand models of argument and controversy in order to widen the ability to hear (in a political sense) culturally based, ethnically-based, class-based, and/or gender-based (and/or intersections thereof) political articulations of difference. "Feminists, Adversaries, and the Integrity of Argument" endeavors to recuperate dimensions of argument and rationality that have come under fire by feminist and multicultural critics for being "too Western to be culturally appropriate for some groups" (46). While conceptual notions mustered against, as well as in defense, of rational argument are faithfully represented, key philosophical and rhetorical scholars are curiously absent. Where is Jacques Derrida's critique of metaphysics and logocentrism? Where is Jurgen Habermas's

defense of communicative action as rational principle, much less his work on theorizing the public sphere? Where is Jean Francois Lyotard's analysis of *Le Différend*? Nancy Fraser's criticism of the public sphere functionally reconfigures Habermas's discourse model into multiple, contested spheres to ensure progressive political philosophy, yet it, too, is not consulted. Readers looking for more than a general overview of key ideas central to negotiating difference while not sacrificing political activism, will not find it in *The Philosophy of Argument*. Even though this chapter is theoretically underdeveloped, it is enjoyable to read. Govier's writing is not bogged down by the complex syntax structures that seem to characterize postmodern literature, thereby rendering key ideas much more accessible to those not familiar with the academic debates and controversies engaged by Derrida *et al.* The chapter reads well and covers the basics, but simultaneously oversimplifies concepts and debates that many trained in contemporary communication and rhetorical scholarship may find bothersome.

Chapter five, "What's Wrong with Slippery Slope Arguments," resembles chapter three in both content and form. Here, Govier builds on arguments presented by a number of scholars over the past 30 years that reexamine the slippery slope fallacy to conclude that, analytically, many arguments of this type need not be judged fallacious. Questions and formulae are provided to help critics and students better judge the probable likelihood of each step in the chain of events that lead to an argument's conclusion. This chapter would prove useful for classroom discussions that seek to demonstrate the contingent nature of labeling arguments fallacious. While Govier concentrates on analytical judgments, it would not take much more effort to extend her models to the critical arena – thereby providing students with an understanding that analytically weak arguments can still hold lots of persuasive appeal, due to their rhetorical constitution.

Chapter six sketches out a brief overview of the movement from formal-logical approaches to argument, to critical, informal approaches to argument. Unlike chapter four, "The Poverty of Formalism" provides more theoretical grounding. In this chapter, Govier poses a series of questions meant continually to focus philosophical investigations on their own assumptions and constitutive elements. In short, the chapter raises the question of whether or not the book's title is appropriate: is there a philosophy of argument? Chapters seven through ten extend these questions through a series of analytical examples. For example, chapter seven, "What is Good Argument?," helps readers reconceptualize the ends of argument away from notions of compelled necessity and sufficiency toward assessing the

relative worth or merit of an arguments “adequacy.” A work in progress, Govier acknowledges the difficulty of pinning down a working definition while resisting the rigid formalism she critiques in chapter six: “In fact, we are so far from having an account of argument cogency which is reasonable, reliable, and efficient that we have to reexamine the quest itself. It would be nice to have something more constructive to offer, but perhaps I can perform a useful service by persuading some of you that there are some interesting problems here” (121).

Chapter eight, “Rosebuds, Judgments, and Critical Thinking” takes up the role that context plays in argument evaluation and judgment. Govier situates her analysis in the context of the critique of rationality, acknowledging that claims of universal-rational principles are never divorced from the epistemic limitations times and socio-cultural paradigms within which such principles are “revealed”/constructed. Echoing the sentiments of Rorty and other pragmatists, Govier insists that acknowledging the ephemeral nature of argument standards and ensuing judgments is itself, always-already a critical act. By embracing rather than resisting the contingent nature of interpretive (cognitive and institutional) schemes and evaluative criteria, we remain faithful to the idea that critical thinking need not be politically paralyzing.

Chapter nine, “Euclid’s Disease and Deperate Violinist: Do Analogies Have Missing Premises,” builds on Govier’s earlier considerations of arguments by analogy. According to Govier, analogies draw on reasoning that is unique to the terms of their own cases. Govier’s writing here is characteristically clear and instructive, and lends itself easily to translations appropriate for classroom considerations. In particular, Govier’s reconsideration of Jarvis Thompson’s “desperate violinist” moral analogy presents a solid rationale for resisting a priori judgment standards when evaluating analogies. Sure, Thompson’s problematic is useful when stated in its original terms, yet when extended into the realms of slavery, war, and smoking its inability to account for the particular circumstances in variant contexts reveals its shortcomings. “Simple formalisms to represent analogy are useful in some ways. But they encourage us to ignore the difficulties we may find in articulating just those respects in which A and B are similar and their bearing on the conclusion drawn” (149). Govier provides further evidence that analogies, inevitably, break down because of how they are constituted. Chapter ten, “Reasoning with Pros and Cons: Conductive Arguments Revisited,” examines those arguments in which an advocate gives reasons for adherence to a claim, while conceding an argument’s limiting oppositions. “Despite the fact,” “even

though,” and “although” indicate that this type of argument is being advanced. The process of giving reasons for and against a conclusion partakes of both inductive and deductive reasoning, depending on the nature of the claim advanced and the reasons given. Again, Govier builds her case with examples that amply demonstrate the shortcomings evaluating arguments with strict deductive and/or inductive criteria. Readers of this journal will find her solution to evaluating this type of argument very familiar: “We commit ourselves to the judgment that, on balance, the pros outweigh the cons, and do so to a sufficient degree that there are good grounds for the conclusion” (170). Participants in high school and college debate already know and work within this framework. Nevertheless, this chapter offers a readable justification for why sub-claims within extended arguments need to be evaluated relative to the unique types of reasoning that undergird them, and judgments need to be rendered holistically.

Chapter eleven, “When They Can’t Talk Back: The Noninteractive Audience and the Theory of Argument,” considers how audience influences and affects the choices that arguers make. Taking issue with the pragma-dialectical school of argument, Govier develops four lines of criticism, concluding that the method of indirect argument evaluation assumed by pragma-dialectics is theoretically insolvent. “When the views of the audience are not known or knowable, relativization of any of these matters to the audience is not a useful theoretical move. . . . Indirect evaluation of such arguments is not feasible, because the audience perspective presumed cannot be made available to the theorist. [Instead], these considerations favor the perspective which makes evaluation direct, as opposed to indirect, because by stressing direct evaluation, we can better offer a more unified and simpler model” (199). In addition, this chapter offers a strong reminder that embracing informal argument modes does not mean simply playing “down” to what audiences are predisposed to believe. Rather, Govier’s theory of argument involves acknowledging the nuanced particulars of each argument exigence while developing reasonable and relevant justifications in support of sets of claims.

Chapter twelve, “Becoming Dialectical: Two Tiers of Argument Appraisal” leads readers through the pros and cons of Ralph Johnson’s argument evaluation scheme. This chapter works well to extend the on-balance criteria for argument evaluation set forth in chapter ten. The two-tiered model of argument appraisal suggests that arguments can be evaluated on the cogency of its premises, first (the logical tier), and then on how well the argument accounts for objections and alternative positions (the dialectic tier). Once again,

Govier incorporates dimensions of rhetorical sensibility into her theory of argument, suggesting that dialectics often overwhelms logical soundness, thereby requiring more than sound reasoning and execution to gain audience adherence. “Even if one has put forward an argument which is in fact sound in the traditional logical sense, that circumstance does not necessarily eliminate the need for a dialectical tier. Those to whom an argument is addressed often do not start out believing or accepting the conclusion and they may continue to resist the conclusion even after the argument has been put to them . . . [and] the move to a dialectical tier is arguably necessary for rational persuasion” (207). Pedagogically, this chapter encourages instructors “to teach people to be aware of a distinction between their own thoughts and what reality is like, to think through alternative positions and to consider objections to their own positions and argument” (219).

Chapter thirteen takes engages the workability of the two tiered model presented in chapter twelve. In particular, Govier develops three problems inherent in the two tiered approach: first, which positions does an advocate need to consider; second, on what grounds are said counter-positions chosen, and; third, how can advocates avoid infinite regress? While the chapter raises these questions, it does not definitely answer them. Like Govier herself, I am not sure whether or not there even exists a way to do so while operating under a largely case-by-case approach to argument criticism.

The final chapter, “The Positive Power of Controversy” attempts to integrate opposition and adversarial dimensions of argument into the emerging literature about controversy. The differences between adversariality and controversy seem largely denotative, suggests Govier. In practice, she writes, the need for opposition to push arguers and audience members beyond that which they already believe and adhere to is crucial. While many models of argument suggest that resolving controversy is a key goal of argument, hers is a model that holds the dialectic as the goal. Contemporary communication studies writings about controversy seem to buttress this view as well. Argument, it appears, is in the midst of being re-conceptualized and re-theorized to have as a key goal not conversion and resolution but, instead, to seek to continually complicate and problematize social problems and the allocation of social resources, which are intellectual as well as material in form.

In the end, *The Philosophy of Argument* presents a series of challenges to contemporary, analytical argument epistemology. For rhetoricians, much of Govier’s writing reiterates and confirms the value of how many critics already approach discursive arguments and public controversies. Rhetorical critics of argument stand to see many of their own insights

through a new set of vocabulary terms, which is always an intellectually rewarding exercise. The book is concise and clear, but is complex at times, and I suspect it would prove to be too abstract for introductory argument courses. With strong contextualization and supplementary reading, *The Philosophy of Argument* would constitute a wise choice for use in upper-division undergraduate and introductory-level graduate argumentation courses.

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